



TO THE NINES

One of the most successful female actors in the South, Nayanthara juggles several business ventures with her filmmaker husband

BY VIDYA S.



NAYANTHARA

39, Actor & Entrepreneur

58 | IN THE SECOND attempt to get her on the phone, a cheerful voice apologises for a 10-minute delay. Without wasting a second beyond the customary niceties, the successful and much-adored actor and entrepreneur, Nayanthara, launches right into describing her brands and business philosophy. Articulate and no-nonsense, you know she means business.

Known as much for headlining powerful and commercially successful women-centric films as for her stylish pairings opposite top actors, Nayanthara's 20-year journey in the film industry has seen her evolve from a Malayalam TV anchor to 'Lady Superstar', entrepreneur, investor and brand ambassador. "When you start thinking about it, you kind of start manifesting it," she says about her decision to venture into business along with her filmmaker husband, Vignesh Shivan. The duo's film production house Rowdy Pictures bankrolled the critically acclaimed

Tamil film *Koozhangal* (2021). The year also saw them launching The Lip Balm Company and invest in Chennai-based start-up Chai Wale.

One of the highest paid female actors in the South, she has had a prolific 2023, too. She debuted in Bollywood opposite Shah Rukh Khan in one of the biggest Hindi hits of this year—*Jawan*. Her business has also gathered pace, with the couple collaborating with professionals to launch skincare brand 9Skin, sanitary napkins brand

Femig, and investing in super foods brand The Divine Foods. "Yes, we do make money off the businesses, but it has to be making a positive difference to the people," she says.

While Shivan analyses the business opportunities, Nayanthara chips in to build the brand and contributes towards the look and feel of the products. "Vignesh and I are quite hands-on. Unless we approve something, it doesn't go out."

The film industry has also taught her many skills that come in handy in her role as a business-woman, primary among them being multitasking. "There is so much work that goes into it, that we get tuned to doing many things at the same time and being available all the time." Fresh off the release of her 75th film, she says there are many more ventures in the offing, and not just limited to beauty and personal care. Her star continues to shine. **BT**

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WHAT KEEPS ME GOING

Challenges are opportunities in disguise. The unwavering support of my team and the belief in the purpose behind my endeavours keep me going

A LIFE LESSON LEARNT ON THE JOB

Adaptability to change. Growth often lies just beyond our comfort zones